

# Setting up Claude

A no-nonsense start. Fifteen minutes, not a course.

---

## 1. Create your account

Go to [claude.ai](https://claude.ai) and sign up, email or a Google/Apple account both work. No credit card needed, the free plan gives you real, genuine use, not a crippled trial. Verify your email and you're straight into a chat.

---

## 2. Know what it actually costs

The free plan is genuinely usable, not a trial you'll hit a wall on in five minutes. If you end up chatting a lot, or want fewer limits, Claude Pro is roughly £16 a month, similar to what ChatGPT or Gemini charge for their equivalent tier. Don't upgrade because a prompt nudges you to, upgrade when you've actually hit a wall on the free plan. You'll know when that happens, it's obvious.

---

## 3. Turn off training on your conversations

Do this before you type anything real into it. Click your profile icon (top right) then Settings, then Privacy. There's a toggle for letting Anthropic use your conversations to improve its models, turn it off if you'd rather your own stuff wasn't read for that. Takes ten seconds, easy to forget once you're actually using the thing.

---

## 4. Pick a model, and don't overthink it

Near your prompt box there's a model picker, and sometimes an effort or thinking level alongside it. Different models trade off speed against how much thinking they do behind the scenes. For everyday stuff, the default is genuinely fine. Save the slower, more thorough option for something that actually needs it, a big piece of writing, a tricky problem, a proper decision, not what to have for dinner.

---

## 5. Set up your first Project

This is the one setting that actually changes how useful Claude is day to day. Left sidebar, Projects, Create project. Give it a name related to what you're actually using it for, not "Project 1". In the project instructions box, tell it who you are and how you want it to talk to you: "I'm a [your job], I prefer short answers with the key point first, not three paragraphs of preamble." Upload two or three relevant documents if you have them, a CV, a brief, whatever. Now every chat inside that project starts already knowing your context instead of cold.

---

## 6. Connect your tools

In Settings, look for Connectors. This is what lets Claude actually see things like your Google Drive, Gmail or Calendar, instead of you copying and pasting everything in by hand every single time. Not essential on

day one, but it's the setting that makes this feel less like a chat window and more like something that actually knows your week.

---

## 7. Turn on memory and set your writing style

In Settings, find Memory and turn it on (it's sometimes tucked under a Capabilities tab depending on which version of the app you're looking at). Then head to Styles and pick a default tone if the standard one doesn't feel like you. Small thing, makes every answer after this feel less generic.

---

## 8. One thing to actually try today

Open your new project and ask it something real, not a test question. "Help me [thing you actually need done this week]." That's it, that's the whole point.

---

*Tech with Soph. Built by a product manager, not a marketing team. [techwithsoph.com](https://techwithsoph.com)*